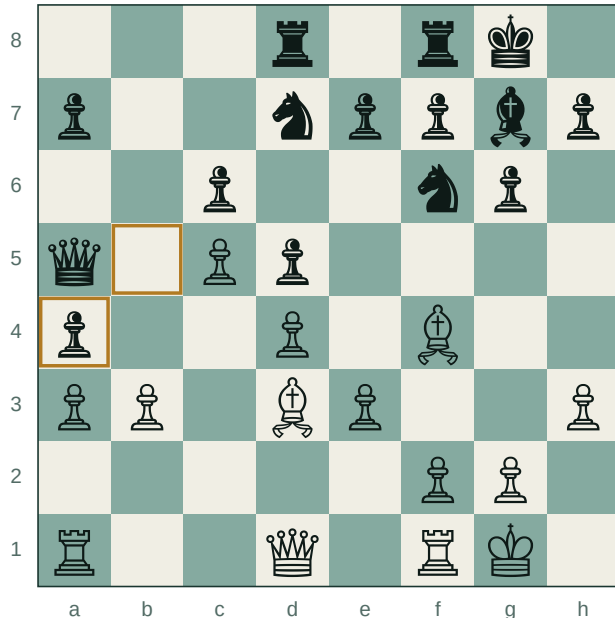


Trapping a piece: White, move 16

Trapping a piece

White to move



Previous move: 15...bxa4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

16. b4 Qb5 17. Bxb5

16.b4 The pawn moves from b3 to b4. Recorded reply: **16...Qb5**.

17.Bxb5 The bishop captures the queen on b5.

At the end, nominal material is White 33 / Black 27 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +9. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +9: the balance goes from -3 to +6. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: queen on a5. Check for tactical protection.